

THIS ISSUE TRAINS · HUNTING THE HIDDEN COSTS

Money and markets

When a card touches a reader, at least five parties move: you, your bank, the shop, the shop's bank, and the payment network in the middle. The network's cut is tiny on each tap and colossal in total.

That is why startups keep attacking payments with cheaper rails, and why the fee structure of moving money is among the most fought over territory in finance. Value in transit always leaks a little; whoever narrows the leak, or owns it, wins.

The SCD takeaway: the fees you never notice decide more than the fees you argue about.

Engineering corner

Zero resistance, if you shape the floor right. Researchers in Sweden showed that sculpting the substrate beneath an ultrathin superconducting film at the nanoscale lets it keep conducting with zero resistance at higher temperatures and stronger magnetic fields. Nothing is lost as current flows, which is why superconductors sit inside MRI machines and fusion experiments.

The SCD takeaway: losing nothing along the way can be worth more than adding power at the source.

Source: ScienceDaily, June 17, 2026.

Your move

A two percent loss sounds like nothing until it applies to every transaction, every trip, every transfer, forever. Small repeated leaks destroy value faster than dramatic one off losses.

This week, on your own: trace one canteen card tap end to end. List everyone who touches the payment and estimate who takes what.